

Tempeh reuben

Virtually every time I see a recipe for a vegetarian Reuben I am disappointed, because often the tofu or tempeh is left as is, unseasoned, as if that part of the **sandwich** were unimportant. Oh, yes, sometimes there is a cursory marinade, but nothing much of any merit. I, of course, call for the sauerkraut, cheese, and rye bread; they are givens with a Reuben. But this tempeh is marinated overnight in flavors that are interesting, compelling you to actually taste the tempeh, not just the condiments.

1 package (8 ounces) tempeh [250g]

2 tablespoons vegetarian Worcestershire sauce

1 tablespoon minced fresh dill or 2 teaspoons dried dill

2 teaspoons nutritional yeast

1 teaspoon onion powder

½ teaspoon caraway seed

½ teaspoon celery seed

1 tablespoon red wine vinegar

1 teaspoon salt

¼ teaspoon freshly ground pepper

1 cup vegetable stock or water [250ml]

Russian Dressing with Sun-Dried Tomatoes (recipe follows) or mustard

4 or 8 slices of rye bread

1 cup jarred sauerkraut, rinsed and drained [125g]

4 slices of Swiss cheese

4 to 6 tablespoons vegetable oil (if pan-frying)

1. **Split** the tempeh in half horizontally to create 2 equal pieces half as thick; cut each piece crosswise to create 4 squares or rectangles.
2. In a large sealable plastic bag, **combine** the Worcestershire sauce, dill, yeast, onion powder, caraway seed, celery seed, vinegar, salt, pepper, and vegetable stock. Add the tempeh to the bag and seal, squeezing out as much air as possible. Turn the bag over a few times to make sure all the pieces are coated with marinade. Refrigerate 8 hours or overnight, turning the bag 2 or 3 times.
3. To bake tempeh: Preheat the oven to 350°F [175°C]. **Arrange** tempeh pieces in a small baking dish in a single layer. Coat with 3 or 4 tablespoons of the marinade and cover with aluminum foil. Bake for 15 minutes.

4. To pan-fry tempeh: In a large nonstick skillet, heat the oil over medium-high heat. Add the tempeh and **fry**, turning once, until golden brown, 2 to 3 minutes on each side. Remove and drain on paper towels.
5. To assemble the sandwich, **spread** the Russian dressing or mustard on bread. Add tempeh, sauerkraut, Swiss cheese, and a second slice of bread. Grill or serve as is.

MAKES 4 MEDIUM-SIZE OR 2 VERY HEARTY SANDWICHES

chef talk

The difference between baking and frying tempeh is significant. Frying tempeh gives it a crispy texture and alters the taste, sort of like the coating for fried chicken or even French fries. For sandwiches, or to present a sauce, I like this technique best. However, you do lose some of the flavor in the cooking pan of any marinade you used.

Baking tempeh, on the other hand, allows you to fully taste the mushroom or nutty tempeh flavor as well as the marinade. And little or no oil is used, which may be important to some. If well coated in liquid and covered, baked tempeh will be moister than fried—meaning, working with tempeh properly is key to the best taste sensations. See the pages 119–120 for details.

Both techniques are good, and each has its own place. Try both methods and see for yourself.